The Blitz & Garden Air Raid Shelters

Key Enquiry Question: How did British families survive 57 consecutive nights of bombing, and what was life like inside a shelter?

LESSON 04
KEY STAGE 2



Source A: *Alan and Doris stepping down into their steel Anderson shelter in their London garden during the 1940 Blitz.*

HISTORICAL READING • WHAT THIS TELLS US

Between September 1940 and May 1941, the German air force bombed British cities for **57 consecutive nights** in a campaign called the Blitz. Over one million London homes were damaged or destroyed.

To protect families, the government provided curved corrugated steel **Anderson shelters** to bury halfway into back gardens covered with soil and turf. In crowded streets without gardens, thousands sheltered in Underground tube stations, sleeping along the platforms.

Task 1: Artifact Detective • Underground Tube Station Shelters

PRIMARY EVIDENCE



Source B: *Shelterers sleeping along the curved platform of Swiss Cottage Underground station during the London Blitz, c. 1940. (London Transport Museum / Imperial War Museum)*

1. Look closely at Source B. Why did over 150,000 Londoners choose to sleep on dusty Underground platforms rather than stay in their own bedrooms or small back garden shelters?

2. Notice the bunks, blankets, and children sleeping. What were the biggest daily challenges (noise, cold, lack of privacy, sanitation) of living communally underground?

Task 2: Active Chronological Challenge • A Night in the Blitz

CHRONOLOGICAL UNDERSTANDING

STAGE 1 • 8:00 PM

The Siren Sounds

The wailing siren gives only three minutes warning. Wardens blow whistles as families scramble outside.

List 3 essential items your family would grab before running into the dark garden:

STAGE 2 • 1:00 AM

The Raids Overhead

High-explosive bombs shake the earth. Searchlights criss-cross the sky and anti-aircraft guns thunder.

What sounds and physical sensations would children experience inside the metal shelter?

STAGE 3 • 6:30 AM

The All-Clear Sounds

The steady continuous siren tone announces morning safety. Families emerge to survey street damage.

What feelings of relief and heartache would neighbours share in the morning light?

Task 3: Visual Investigation • Draw an Anderson Shelter & Survival Kit

TACTILE INVESTIGATION

Draw your Anderson shelter showing the curved corrugated steel roof, soil mound, and entrance.

1. Paraffin Hurricane Lamp & Matches
Why was having safe lighting vital inside the pitch-black, windowless shelter?

2. Woollen Blankets & Hot Water Bottle
How did families survive freezing winter nights with cold, damp soil floors?

3. Flask of Hot Tea & Tin of Biscuits
Why was sharing warm food and drink so important for maintaining high spirits?

4. Battery Radio & Pack of Playing Cards
Why did parents need games, stories, and songs to distract anxious children?

Task 4: "Thinking Heads" • Contrasting Historical Perspectives

CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

1 Mother Sheltering in Garden Anderson

What thoughts run through your mind as you hold your children in the damp, shaking shelter listening to overhead bombers?

2 Auxiliary Fireman (AFS) on the Street

What immense dangers do you face clambering across burning rooftops to extinguish incendiary bombs with water hoses?

Task 5: Mission Challenge • Courage Under Fire

HISTORIAN CHALLENGE

Big Question: Why was British civilian resilience and community solidarity described as the 'secret weapon' that prevented Hitler from breaking Britain's morale during the Blitz?